Judge Puts Limits on Search for Noncitizen Voters

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Elections for **Congress** are less than two weeks away. A judge in California has put limits on a government search for **noncitizens** on voter lists.

A voter list, or **voter roll**, shows who is signed up to vote. In the United States, only citizens may vote in **federal elections**. Voting by **noncitizens** is already against the law, and it is extremely rare.

Since August, the Department of Homeland Security, or DHS, has had hundreds of agents looking for voter fraud. The judge said agents cannot stop people for interviews unless they think the person is a noncitizen. The ruling covers nine states, including California, New York and Georgia. The judge worried that DHS lists had mistakes and included citizens.

In another case, the Department of Justice says about 20,000 **noncitizens** are on California's **voter rolls**. California officials say they are not sure that list is correct. Another court hearing is set for next Tuesday.

Word Treasure

elections -- Times when people vote to choose leaders.
Congress -- The group of lawmakers who make laws for the whole United States.
noncitizens -- People living in a country who are not its citizens.
voter roll -- An official list of people signed up to vote.
federal -- Having to do with the national government of the United States.

Background you need

In the United States, only citizens can vote in national elections, and each state keeps a list of signed-up voters.

When people disagree about whether the government is following the law, a judge can decide and set limits.

Break it down

WHO: A federal judge in California and the Department of Homeland Security
WHAT: The judge limited a DHS search for noncitizens on voter lists
WHERE: Nine states, including California, New York and Georgia
WHY: The judge worried the DHS lists had mistakes and included citizens

Why it matters

Fair rules for voting help make sure every citizen's vote counts, including your family's.

Test what you remember

1. What did the judge in California do?

(A) Cancelled the elections
(B) Closed all the schools
(C) Put limits on a search for noncitizen voters
(D) Made voting online only

2. Who may vote in federal elections in the United States?

(A) Only citizens
(B) Anyone visiting
(C) Only judges
(D) Only children

3. How many states does the ruling cover?

(A) Twenty
(B) One
(C) Three
(D) Nine

4. Which government department had agents looking for voter fraud?

(A) The Department of Education
(B) The Post Office
(C) The Department of Homeland Security
(D) NASA

5. Why was the judge worried about the DHS lists?

(A) They were too colorful
(B) They had mistakes and included citizens
(C) They were too short
(D) They were lost

6. When is another court hearing set?

(A) Never
(B) In ten years
(C) Next Tuesday
(D) Last year

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: D 4: C 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. **The judge: Worried DHS lists had mistakes and included citizens.**
2. **California officials: Are not sure the Justice Department's list of 20,000 noncitizens is correct.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):